

WARP 'N WEFT
A Harshang design carpet from Shahsavan, Iran; David and Mandeep Housego



EXHIBITION

'RUG'GED TALES

The Nomad exhibition invites the audience to explore the world of 19th- and 20th-century textiles from Turkey, Iran and Turkestan

After traversing the Silk Route through 'Bukhara'—an exhibition that turned the spotlight on textiles like Suzani, and carpets and techniques unique to Central Asia in the 19th century—the founders of Shades of India, David and Mandeep Housego, have returned with a new showcase at Delhi's sprawling National Crafts Museum.

Titled 'Nomad: The Art of Tribal Weaves across Borders from Anatolia to Tibet', the exhibition (on till February 12) brings together some of the most exceptional rugs, gelims (flat woven rugs), horse blankets and saddle bags from the region. The 50-plus pieces on display from the 19th and early 20th century, made from hand-spun and hand-woven wool, mostly come from David and Mandeep's personal collection. Danny and Renuka Mehra have also lent some pieces



A 19th-century carpet from southwest Persia

from their vast collection. "The innovation and creativity of the nomadic tribes who move every year from the lowlands in the winter to the high mountain pastures in the summer is exceptional. They have great aesthetic sense," says David.

Interestingly, each of the tribal groups that inhabit this vast area—Kurds and Turks from Anatolia, Kurds from western Iran, the Shahsavan from northwestern Iran, the Qashqai, Bakhtiars, Khamseh and Afshar from the west and south of Iran, the Baluch and Turkmens from eastern Iran and Turkestan to the north—have a unique design language.

"The living of these people is based around wool. Much of my work as a former journalist took me to Iran and Afghanistan—that's how I was exposed to these textile traditions. It is during our travels that Mandeep and I have gathered many of these pieces," adds David. Superior in colour and form, these rugs have red, indigo blue, green and black as dominant shades. The designs draw from abstract paintings. One of the most widely used motifs is the boteh (paisley) that can be found in pieces from the Caucasus as well as from western Iran and Central Asia. There could also be a link to India, according to David. "What strikes me continually is these people from rural backgrounds are making things that are extremely sophisticated. These are not the rugs you generally see in people's houses; they are much richer," he says.

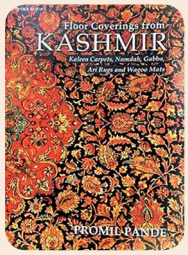
Curated by Amita Goel, the aim of this exhibition is to bring forth a tradition to Indian audiences they haven't previously been exposed to. "Last year, when we did 'Bukhara', people who came to the exhibition were really excited to see the showcase. With 'Nomad', we have again chosen some outstanding pieces that are relatively unknown in India. It will be a revelation to people," concludes David. ■

– Geetika Sachdev

BOOKLIST

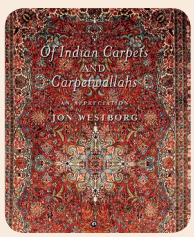
What Lies Beneath

Two odes to our never-ending affair with carpets



FLOOR COVERINGS FROM KASHMIR: Kaleen Carpets, Namdah, Gabba, Ari Rugs and Wagoo Mats
by Promil Pande
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹2,500; 236 pages

A scholarly work , it covers everything from wagoo mats—a tradition of great antiquity—to the more recent craft of carpet-weaving, about 600 years old, making it a rich repository of information. The academic tone is lightened by the lush photographs of heritage carpets.



OF INDIAN CARPETS AND CARPETWALLAHS
An Appreciation
by Jon Westborg
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹999; 162 pages

Retired Norwegian diplomat Jon Westborg, who was born in Darjeeling and spent his childhood in Assam, developed a passionate interest in carpets after his first Delhi posting in 1990. Here, he tells the story of Indian carpet-making through the unique histories of the carpets he has collected over the years, from exquisite Kashmiri ones to one made in Rampur Jail.